Former Teachers: Barriers, Incentives and Policy Lessons for Re-entry

Directorate for Education and Skills

WORKING DRAFT

Abstract

Résumé

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1. Introduction

Pendiente de escribir (al final de todo). Yo creo que aquí es clave resaltar los aprendizajes y que alguien que lea esto se quede con todo lo importante. Si alguien quiere detalles de research, que pueda pasar a la sección 2, y si quieren solo policy que pasen a 3.

Re-attracting former teachers has become one of the policy margins through which governments are trying to alleviate the current problem of teacher shortages. Although not sufficient to close the gap on its own, it can help reduce and fill vacancies in the short run, especially in the disadvantaged and rural schools where shortages tend to concentrate (UNESCO, 2024; Carver-Thomas and Darling-Hammond, 2019; Nguyen, Lam and Bruno, 2024). The magnitude of this policy margin depends on the baseline leaving and retirement rates, since in countries such as France, Greece, Ireland or Israel, whose low leaving rates are almost solely explained by retirement, its potential is scarce (OECD, 2025a). Beyond short-run relief to shortages, returners and retired teachers can bring benefits of their own, such as positive experience spillovers to colleagues, mentorship for beginning teachers and tutoring roles with experimental backing (Papay et al., 2020; DeCesare et al., 2017; Nickow, Oreopoulos and Quan, 2024).

2. Teacher leaving: rates, determinants and implications for re-entry

To design and evaluate the impact of policies that aim to bring former teachers back to the classroom it is fundamental to have a thorough understanding of the reasons why teachers leave. Moreover, it is crucial to identify the experiences and added value that former teachers can bring back to educational systems if they are successfully reintegrated. This debate is of central importance for governments that are making a wide range of efforts to retain and re-attract former teachers in response to the pressing challenges of an ageing teaching workforce, serious teacher shortages and the rising concerns over teachers' burnout and lack of mentorship (OECD, 2025a; UNESCO, 2024; Madigan and Kim, 2021; OECD, 2025b). This section therefore reviews what is known about why teachers leave, before the paper turns to the policies that have tried to bring them back.

First, we distinguish three main profiles of former teachers: (1) switchers, those who resign from teaching to take up other part-time or full-time employment, (2) leavers, those who withdraw from the labour market, and (3) retired teachers who have reached the end of their working lives. The determinants of leaving and the opportunity cost that each group faces when considering whether to re-enter vary significantly across these profiles. As the evidence reviewed in this section shows, switchers leave mainly over the conditions of the job and the standing of the profession, and pay weighs less in their decision than is often assumed; leavers leave for reasons that lie outside the school, mostly family and health, and respond above all to flexibility; and retired teachers leave when pension rules make it worthwhile, and are kept out of the classroom by those same rules once they have retired.

These institutional factors are nonetheless highly country-dependent, and a comprehensive description would require a paper of its own. Here we instead, we first describe the evolution and scope of the teacher leaving rate and posteriorly develop a general framework that classifies the most common motives for leaving and illustrates them with selected country examples. Each area of reasons closes with its implications for re-entry and with the profile it mainly concerns, and Box 1 at the end of the section brings them together.

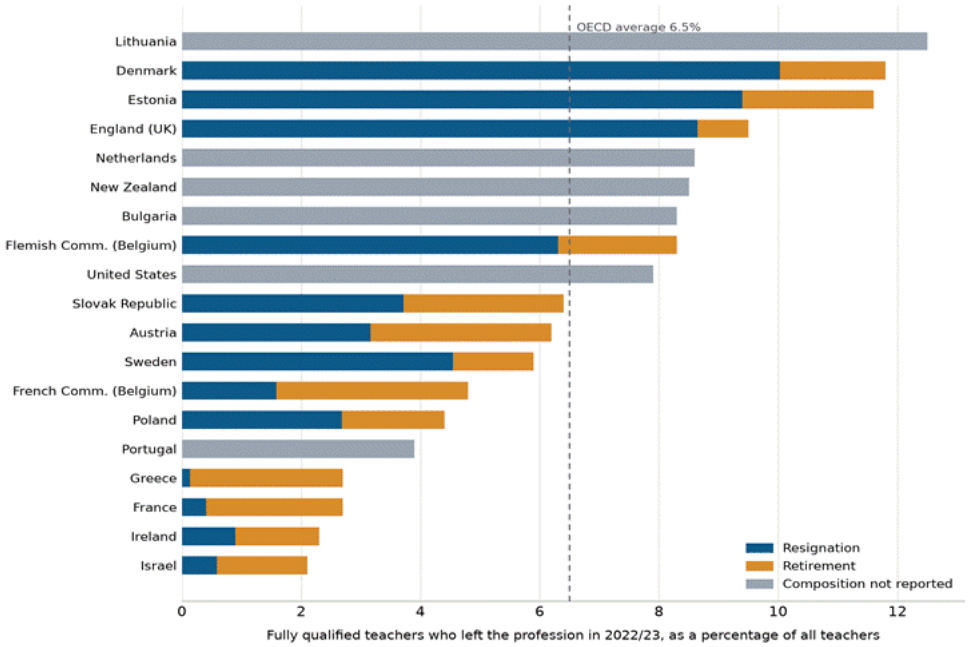
2.1 The teacher leaving rate and its evolution

The average teacher leaving rate across OECD countries was 6.5% in 2023, with considerable differences among the countries with available data (OECD, 2025a; see Figure 1). In countries with rates close to 2%, such as Israel, Ireland, France and Greece, the workforce renews itself through retirement

alone. In countries with higher rates, such as Lithuania, Denmark or Estonia, a larger share of departures corresponds to leavers and switchers. These systems must replace a substantial part of their stock every year, which raises questions about working conditions and retention.

The evolution of the leaving rate across time tends to be stable in most of the observed countries. The OECD average leaving rate moved from 6.9% in 2015 to 6.5% in 2023 and most systems present in both years moved by less than a percentage point (OECD, 2025a). Moreover, studies developed in countries with the longest available series confirm this stable trend. In USA, which holds one of the longest-running national series, the rate has oscillated between 5% and 8.5% across three and a half decades of survey waves, has sat near 8% for the last twenty years, and carries no lasting mark from the pandemic increase (NCES, 2024), and similar patterns hold in England, New Zealand, Sweden, Israel, Iceland, Norway and Flanders (Department for Education, 2024a; Education Counts, 2025; Adermon and Laun, 2018; CBS Israel, 2023; Björnsdóttir and Hansen, 2024; Statistics Norway, 2025; Vansteenkiste, 2025).

Figure 1. The teacher leaving rate and its composition, 2022/23



Note: Share of fully qualified teachers, full-time and part-time in public institutions, who left the profession during the reference year, from pre-primary to upper secondary education. The split into resignations and retirements is shown where reported; grey bars report the total rate only. The OECD average refers to the 19 countries and economies with available data. The reference year differs from 2022/23 for Denmark, France, New Zealand and England (2021/22). Data refer to primary and lower secondary education combined and exclude upper secondary education in Denmark, exclude upper secondary education in Israel and upper secondary vocational education in the Netherlands, and include non-fully qualified teachers in the Netherlands, New Zealand and the Flemish Community of Belgium. For the United States, leavers include teachers appointed to other positions in the education sector.

Source: OECD (2025a), Education at a Glance 2025, Table D8.4.

Regardless of how stable the leaving rate is over time, the teachers who make it up constitute a relevant policy margin. They are already trained, they have much to offer the education system, and they can bring back valuable experience gained in and outside the classroom, which also makes them a credible source for covering the local teacher shortages that most OECD

systems face today (OECD, 2026). The extent to which this margin can be mobilised depends, however, on the reasons that led these teachers to leave, both because those reasons are the levers through which systems can reduce departures and because they condition the design of any policy that seeks to bring former teachers back. The following section reviews what the literature has established on them.

2.2 Determinants of teachers leaving

The reasons why teachers leave the profession have been studied extensively, through surveys and interviews and, more recently, through administrative records of observed departures. Despite this abundance of evidence, ranking the reasons remains difficult. Studies differ in the populations they follow, in the outcomes they measure and in the way motives are grouped. Building on a comprehensive review of this literature and on the two most recent meta-analyses (Nguyen et al., 2020; Gundlach, Slemp and Hattie, 2024), this paper classifies the reasons into six reasons stated in Table 1. They are presented in this section starting with those that the evidence identifies as most important and ending with the least studied. Each area closes with its implications for policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, and Box 1 at the end of the section summarizes them.

Table 1. Reasons for leaving teaching, by area

Area	Reasons
Professional factors	Loss of professional purpose; limited autonomy over the work; professional standing; exposure to parental complaint and legal risk
Working conditions	Hours and total workload; pupil behaviour and classroom discipline; administrative and documentation demands; limited access to reduced hours; burnout and exhaustion
Organisational factors	School leadership; collegial support and team structure
Accountability and regulation	External inspection and its consequences; certification and licensing requirements
Financial factors	Salary relative to outside options; pension design and its timing incentives; contract insecurity
Personal and life-course factors	Family formation and care; childbirth; health and incapacity; relocation and a partner's circumstances; retirement and career stage

Source: Authors' elaboration on the literature reviewed in this section.

Working conditions

First, working conditions are the most frequently declared reason for intending to leave in international surveys. The area groups working hours and total workload, pupil behaviour and classroom discipline, class size,

administrative demands and the burnout that accumulates when these run together. Workload is understood here as the total time that teaching requires, in the school and in preparation and marking outside it, rather than the hours stipulated by contract. According to TALIS 2024, one in four teachers across the OECD intends to leave the profession within five years, and teachers who report high levels of stress are almost twice as likely to declare that intention. That stress comes mainly from administrative work and marking, from keeping up with changing government requirements and from maintaining classroom discipline (OECD, 2025b).

The surveys that ask leavers about the motives of their decision point particularly to workload, which emerges as the most cited motive among those related to working conditions. Leaver surveys done in the Netherlands, Sweden and Australia are consistent in this respect, although assigning different weights to what workload implies. In the Netherlands, workload, stress and burden were named ahead of every other category by 47% of recent leavers, who described intense working days, little rest within them and recurrent overtime, and 80% of them declared that they could have been retained, most often with less workload or a smaller class (Van Casteren et al., 2023). In Sweden, workload and parental expectations also came first, followed by administrative tasks and the lack of control over one's own work (Statistics Sweden, 2023), while in Australia the intensification of workload ranked second, behind dissatisfaction with school leadership, which is examined later in this section (Brandenburg et al., 2024).

However, teachers do not work longer hours than comparable professionals, when TALIS 2024 responses are compared with those of similarly qualified workers in the Survey of Adult Skills (PIAAC), teachers report fewer weekly hours in 13 of 26 covered countries and no clear difference in another 11 (OECD, 2025b). Hence, the workload that teachers declare goes beyond the number of hours stipulated by contract and mainly reflects the intensity of the work, the preparation and administrative tasks carried out outside school hours, and the burden they perceive in the classroom. A great example is observed in England, where TALIS responses were linked to administrative registers of the school workforce, so actual departures could be observed. Teachers in schools with worse discipline were twice as likely to leave the profession while the number of hours teachers worked did not predict their departure (Sims and Jerrim, 2020).

For policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, these findings carry two implications. The first is that the school and the teaching load offered to a returner are part of the policy, since the discipline climate of the school and the load are what drive departures (Sims and Jerrim, 2020; Van Casteren et al., 2023). Hence re-attraction is an opportunity to make a better match between the returning teacher and the school they arrive to. The second follows from the fact that shortages tend to concentrate in disadvantaged and rural schools, where the classroom climate is worst (Simon and Johnson, 2015; UNESCO, 2024): a former teacher sent back to one of these schools on the strength of an incentive alone would meet precisely the conditions that drive departures.

Organisational Factors

Closely linked to the daily pressures of teaching, organisational factors cover the quality of school leadership, the structuring of collaborative time and the degree of support among colleagues. Among these, dissatisfaction with school leadership is one of the most frequently cited predictors of teacher departure (Boyd et al., 2011; Ladd, 2011; Simon and Johnson, 2015). Nonetheless, establishing its causal effect is difficult, since teachers and principals self-select into schools and the association partly reflects that sorting rather than the effect of leadership itself.

The studies that overcome this problem, by following the same schools over time or by linking teachers' answers to administrative records of actual departures, confirm that leadership is central. Where teachers perceive their school to be well led, turnover is substantially lower, even after accounting for the other working conditions and for the characteristics of the students, and when the leadership of a school improves, its turnover falls (Boyd et al., 2011; Ladd, 2011; Kraft, Marinell and Shen-Wei Yee, 2016). The effect is largest precisely in disadvantaged schools, where an effective principal makes the greatest difference to whether teachers stay (Grissom, 2011).

Additionally, mentorship is another relevant organizational aspect, as it accelerates the pedagogical development of novice educators and mitigates the professional isolation common in early-career years. Across the OECD, however, only 26% of novice teachers had an assigned mentor in 2024, although four in five worked in schools that offer a mentoring programme (OECD, 2025b). Novice teachers who receive induction support are less likely to leave the profession (Nguyen et al., 2020), and precisely for this reason structured induction programmes have become one of the most common retention policies, with encouraging results where they have been evaluated. In England, for instance, the Early Career Framework, which entitles every new teacher to two years of mentoring, has increased retention within the original school (Walker et al., 2024). More broadly, collegial support and collaborative environments are consistently associated with lower intentions to leave (Johnson, Kraft and Papay, 2012; Simon and Johnson, 2015).

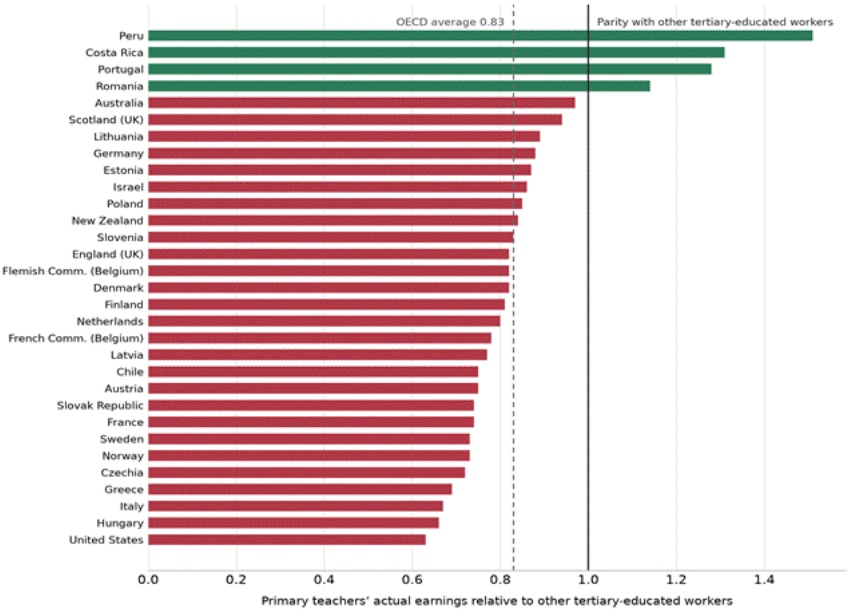
For policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, organisational factors matter in two ways. The first concerns the school to which returners are sent, since leadership and collegial support are decisive for all three profiles and a teacher who returns to a school with weak leadership encounters the same conditions that produced the first departure. For this reason, the return process itself could include early contact between the returning teacher and the leadership of the receiving school, so that the match is assessed before the placement is made. The second concerns the contribution that retired teachers can make, since in systems where fewer than one in three novice teachers has a mentor, experienced returners can fill that gap, and the peer interaction they bring has been shown to improve the instruction of their colleagues (Papay et al., 2020; DeCesare et al., 2017).

Financial factors

Thirdly, financial factors are the most extensively studied determinant of teacher retention. The area covers the salary relative to outside options, the design of pensions and the insecurity of contracts. From an economic perspective, retention depends on comparing teaching wages with the best alternative available outside. Because outside options vary by subject,

qualification and local labour market, uniform pay scales produce very different exit rates across disciplines and regions. For most teachers the comparison is unfavourable. Actual primary teacher salaries average 83% of the earnings of tertiary-educated workers across the OECD, with large differences across countries (see Figure 2). Only four systems pay at or above parity, led by Portugal at 128% of the benchmark, while the United States registers the lowest ratio at 63% (OECD, 2025d).

Figure 2. Teachers' salary compared to other tertiary-educated workers earnings



Note: Ratio of the average actual salary of full-time primary teachers in public institutions to the earnings of full-time tertiary-educated workers aged 25 to 64. Data refer to 2024 or the nearest available year.

Source: OECD (2025d), Education at a Glance 2025, Table D3.2.

The causal evidence on the effect of teacher payments confirms that financial incentives are effective to retain teachers, and payments cut departures by 9% to 23% in Norway, England and North Carolina (Falch, 2011; Sims and Benhenda, 2022; Clotfelter et al., 2008). This evidence rests on a small number of studies exploiting policy discontinuities, and lead to three main conclusions. Financial incentives are effective when the payment is large and teachers are aware of their eligibility (Falch, 2011; Clotfelter et al., 2008); their effect is confined to the teachers they target and is negligible for the rest (Springer, Swain and Rodriguez, 2016); and one-off bonuses produce larger short-run effects than permanent increases, which indicates that the retention gain does not persist beyond the payment period (Feng and Sass, 2018; See et al., 2020).

Moreover, pension rules also affect the decision to leave, since they set the retirement age and, along the teaching career, create incentives for retention depending on the pension system's rigidity. The retirement age generally falls between 62 and 67, averaging 64.7 for men and 63.9 for women across the OECD. It stands at 62 in Greece and Slovenia, at 67 in Australia, Denmark, Iceland, Israel, the Netherlands and Norway, and in between everywhere else (OECD, 2025f). In most schemes covering teachers, retiring before the age stipulated by law reduces the pension and retiring later marginally increases it, so retirement concentrates around that age (Baraton, Beffy and Fougère, 2011; Ni and Podgursky, 2016). In addition, in many public-service schemes

the pension is not freely compatible with a new salary, and retired teacher who returns sees the pension reduced or suspended once pension and salary together exceed a given threshold, which in practice excludes most retirees from teaching again unless a specific exception is made.

These rules matter because they shape the economic decisions that teachers take around retirement, and this phenomenon is closely related to the way pension entitlements accumulate. In defined-benefit schemes, where the pension is a share of the final salary that depends on years of service rather than on the contributions actually paid, most of the pension is earned in the final years before the full-pension age and little accrues after it, so one more year of work carries a substantial pension gain at 54 and almost nothing at 60 (Costrell and Podgursky, 2009). This is mostly the case across the civil-service teacher schemes of Europe and North America. Defined-contribution systems, where the pension depends on what has been contributed and on the return it has earned, as in Sweden or Australia, are instead close to actuarially neutral and spread retirements accordingly (OECD, 2025e). The available estimates of how much teachers value that deferred income present mixed results, with estimates running from about 20 cents per dollar of present value to near parity (Fitzpatrick, 2015; Ni, Podgursky and Wang, 2022), which suggests that the retention effect of pension rules depends as much on how well teachers understand them as on their actual generosity.

For policies that seek to re-attract former teachers, these findings carry two implications. The first concerns retired teachers, for whom pension rules are the main obstacle to returning, the more flexibility a system offers them to teach again without losing their pension, and with the possibility of earning an additional income, the more effective it will be in re-attracting them, which is the logic behind several of the policies examined in Section 3. The second concerns switchers, for whom, as expected, better salaries increase the likelihood of returning. The causal evidence reviewed above nonetheless warns that pay alone retains teachers only while it is paid, so that keeping returners in the profession depends on the working and organisational conditions discussed in the previous areas rather than on the financial incentive that brought them back.

Professional factors

Fourth, professional factors group the motives related to the purpose, autonomy and standing of teaching. This area covers teachers who leave because they no longer find meaning in their work, who feel they have lost control over how to exercise it, or who perceive a deterioration in the standing of the profession, often linked to exposure to parental complaints and legal action.

The available evidence consistently shows that these motives weigh on the decision to leave, both among teachers who intend to leave and among those who have already done so. In Finland a longitudinal survey that followed teachers over five years found that a lack of professional commitment was named persistently, above workload and interpersonal difficulties among teachers declaring an intention to leave the profession (Räsänen et al., 2020). In England teachers who intend to leave give more weight to the feeling that their views are not considered by policymakers than to wages (Department for Education, 2024b). Among actual leavers, the pattern remains consistent. In

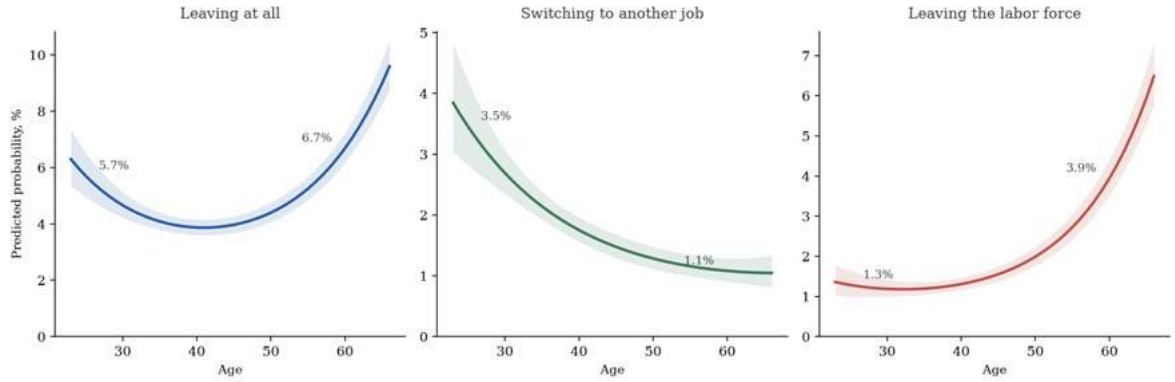
the United States, most switchers rate their new job above teaching in autonomy, influence and professional prestige, although not always in salary (NCES, 2014), and in the leaver surveys of the Netherlands and Sweden the lack of professional challenge and the limited control over one's own work rank among the leading motives, behind working conditions only (Van Casteren et al., 2023; Statistics Sweden, 2023).

Moreover, the apparent decline in the perceived standing of the profession is not only a problem for those who decide to leave. Across the OECD, only 26% of teachers feel that their profession is valued in society, and those who do are over 10% less likely to intend to leave within five years (OECD, 2020; OECD, 2025b). Taken together, the evidence points to recognition and professional purpose as decisive in the leaving decision, consistent with teaching remaining one of the most vocational career choices. This matters for policies that seek to bring former teachers back, and particularly switchers, who are the ones who found elsewhere the autonomy and standing they missed, since it highlights the importance of recognising their previous service, of offering roles that make use of their experience and of initiatives that increase their participation in decisions about their own work.

Personal and life-course factors

Fifth, personal and life-course factors drive a substantial share of departures and, unlike the preceding areas, originate entirely outside the school, which makes them the least predictable from an institutional perspective and the least responsive to standard administrative aspects. Along the teaching career, the leaving rate exhibits a pronounced U-shape, concentrated among novice teachers during early-career sorting and among late-career teachers approaching retirement, with a stable middle phase (Nguyen et al., 2020). Figure 3 shows this profile for the United States and separates the two exit routes behind it.

Figure 3. The age profile of leaving teaching in the United States, by exit route



Note: Predicted probabilities of leaving teaching within twelve months, by age, from probit models estimated on Current Population Survey data (March supplements) for college-graduate teachers observed between 2015 and 2024. Each panel comes from a separate model, with age entered as a quadratic, year effects, and the other covariates held at their sample means. Left: leaving teaching by any route; centre: moving to another occupation; right: leaving the labour force. Exits to unemployment are the residual route and are not shown, so the two right panels do not sum exactly to the left one. Shaded bands are 95% confidence intervals. Authors' calculations.

The early peak is driven by switchers, since the probability of moving to another occupation is highest among the youngest teachers and declines steadily with age, as novice teachers leave for further study, family formation or alternative employment while the quality of their match with the profession

is still being revealed (Guarino, Santibañez and Daley, 2006). The late peak is driven by leavers, whose probability of withdrawing from the labour force rises sharply after the age of 55 in response to the retirement incentives just examined (Costrell and Podgursky, 2009).

The teaching workforce is predominantly female, at around seven in ten lower secondary teachers across the OECD (OECD, 2025b). The events of family life weigh on it with particular force, and the birth of a child is the best documented of these motives. In England, where the workforce census follows teachers after maternity leave, between 17% and 20% of those who return leave the profession within a year, doubling the rate of comparable teachers, and women aged 30 to 39 form the largest group among leavers (Department for Education, 2023). Similarly in the United States and Sweden the same event has long driven female exits (Stinebrickner, 2002).

However, childbirth is only the most visible of a broader set of family and health circumstances that lead teachers to withdraw from the labour market, and the leaver surveys that record them show that these circumstances weigh as much as childbirth itself. Personal life reasons, covering health, childcare and the care of relatives, form the most important non-retirement motive among American voluntary leavers, at 15% (NCES, 2024), and the difficulty of combining work and family is named by 15% of Swedish leavers (Statistics Sweden, 2023).

This matters for policies that seek to bring former teachers back, since those who left over a birth or a family obligation did not leave over the conditions of the school, and the constraint behind the exit tends to ease with time. The evidence nonetheless suggests that their return does not follows on its own when the family circumstances that generated the leaving decision have ceased, only a minority of those who leave come back (Grissom and Reininger, 2012; Moyer, 2022). Flexibility therefore emerges as the central lever for this profile. Part-time and phased returns, predictable timetables and placements compatible with care responsibilities improve re-entry in general and, above all, facilitate the return of those who leave temporarily.

Accountability and regulation

Finally, accountability and regulation group the motives related to external teacher evaluation and to statutory licensing rules. In general, the evaluation of teachers can be divided into internal evaluations, carried out by the school's own leadership, and external evaluation, carried out by a public body, usually a national or regional inspection regulated by education ministries or equivalent authorities. The internal revisions are common, since 64% of teachers across the OECD work in schools where the principal evaluates every teacher at least once a year and 51% in schools where other members of the management team do so, most often on the basis of classroom observation (OECD, 2020).

Beyond evaluation, maintaining a valid teaching license requires meeting specific regulatory obligations that vary by country, typically taking the form of mandatory periodic training or documented evidence of continued classroom practice. The obligation consists either of completing training, which ranges from 8 hours a year in Luxembourg to 35 in Scotland and from three to five days in Belgium, Finland, Cyprus, Lithuania and Slovenia (European Commission/EACEA/Eurydice, 2021), or of a minimum amount of

teaching, such as 20 days a year in Australia or two years of classroom practice in New Zealand (Victorian Institute of Teaching, 2025; Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand, 2016).

However, what matters for leavers is the additional time and work these obligations imply, since nearly half report that evaluation in their school is carried out merely to fulfil administrative requirements, without producing feedback they can use, and 54% that their mandatory training competes with their working schedule (OECD, 2020). The importance of accountability and regulation motives is nonetheless minor compared to other determinants of leaving, since even if test-based accountability does elevate stress and turnover intentions (Ryan et al., 2017), it ranks below affective commitment, burnout and job satisfaction (Gundlach, Slemp and Hattie, 2024).

For policies aiming to re-attract former teachers, this suggests that the cost of re-certification deserves particular attention. Licensing requirements rarely drive fully qualified teachers out of the profession, although teachers who entered without full certification do leave at higher rates (Redding and Smith, 2016), but they become a real barrier at the moment of return, since a lapsed licence must be renewed and the cost and the isolation that teachers face in navigating the process deter re-entry and reduce retention once back. This concerns all three profiles and argues for keeping such burdens as low as regulatory purposes allow.

General overview

Not all these motives have been studied with the same intensity, and their relative importance cannot be compared perfectly across studies. The best basis for doing so comes from the two meta-analyses used throughout this section, which together pool several hundred studies of teacher turnover and estimate the weight of each antecedent for intentions as well as for observed departures (Nguyen et al., 2020; Gundlach, Slemp and Hattie, 2024). Both point to working conditions and the organisational features of the school as the most consistent determinants of leaving, above financial incentives, accountability and personal characteristics. Teachers exposed to high workload, stress and weak organisational support are substantially more likely to leave, while pay and regulation, although relevant, have smaller effects. This does not make personal motives secondary for every teacher. It means that the conditions under which teaching takes place are the main institutional margin through which systems can influence retention.

This distinction matters for policies that aim to re-attract former teachers. Bringing a teacher back without changing the conditions under which they left risks reproducing the same decision later on. Re-entry policies should therefore be understood not only as a way to reduce the cost of returning, but as an opportunity to improve the match between teachers and schools, a manageable load, supportive leadership and colleagues, adequate classroom conditions and, where the exit was personal, the flexibility to combine teaching with family responsibilities. The relevant question is not simply how to make former teachers return, but whether the system can offer them a different set of conditions once they do.

Box 1. What the reasons for leaving teach us about re-attracting former teachers

Each reason for leaving points to a profile of former teachers and to a lever for bringing them back.

Working conditions. *Switchers and leavers.* What drives departures is the climate of the classroom more than the hours worked. Because shortages concentrate in the schools where that climate is worst, a returner placed there on the strength of an incentive alone is likely to leave again. The school a returner is placed in and the teaching load they are offered are part of the policy.

Organisational factors. *All profiles.* Supportive leadership and collegial support are the most consistent predictors of staying, so returners should go to schools where they exist. Retired teachers can also supply what is missing: only one in four novice teachers has a mentor, and mentoring is the organisational lever with the clearest effect on early-career retention.

Financial factors. *Switchers and retired teachers.* Pay brings teachers back and keeps them only for as long as it is paid. For retired teachers the binding constraint is not the salary but the pension rules that penalise working after retirement; removing those penalties costs little and acts directly on the largest reserve of experienced teachers.

Professional factors. *Mainly switchers.* Those who leave for another job rate it above teaching in autonomy, influence and standing, more than in pay. Bringing them back means recognising their previous service, offering roles that use their experience and giving them a say in decisions about their own work.

Personal and life-course factors. *Mainly leavers.* Those who left over a birth, care or health did not leave over the school, and the constraint often eases with time. Yet they no longer return on their own: only about one in five does. They respond to flexibility, through part-time and phased returns, predictable timetables and placements compatible with care, and to being asked.

Accountability and regulation. *Minor as a reason for leaving, decisive for re-entry.* Licensing and training obligations rarely drive qualified teachers out, but a lapsed licence must be renewed, and the cost and complexity of doing so deter those considering a return. Re-certification should be as light as its purpose allows.

Overall. Working conditions and the organisation of the school outweigh pay, regulation and personal characteristics as reasons for leaving. The conditions a former teacher returns to therefore matter as much as the incentive that brings them back, and a policy driven only by shortages, which places returners in the hardest schools, risks reproducing the first departure. Seen in this light, re-entry policies are also an opportunity to improve the match between teachers and schools, through the workload, the leadership, the collegial environment, the classroom conditions and the flexibility that returners are offered.

3. The policies

This section reviews the policies that education systems have used to bring former teachers back into schools. It draws on 30 policies from 18 countries, collected by the authors from official documents, legal texts, parliamentary records, institutional evaluations and, where no official source exists, reputable press, and on exchanges with ministry officials in Lower Saxony (Germany), Quebec (Canada) and New Zealand. Every policy was verified against its primary sources in October 2026. The policies are grouped by the main instrument they use, following the five categories set out in Table 2: financial incentives, information and nudges, support and training, flexible positions and flexible re-certification. Many policies combine more than one instrument, and each is presented under the one that defines it best.

3.1 An overview of the policies

Most of the policies reviewed were designed to respond to teacher shortages, and many to shortages that were local, concentrated in particular subjects or regions, or sudden. A large group was introduced or extended during the COVID-19 pandemic, when absences among serving teachers multiplied the need for substitutes: Quebec created its incentives for retired teachers in autumn 2020 under the health emergency, Ontario temporarily raised the number of days retirees may work without losing their pension, Ireland waived pension abatement for retired substitutes in 2021, and England called former teachers back to cover absences during the Omicron wave of winter 2021-22. A smaller group pursues a different aim, which is to put the experience of former teachers to use in roles that serving teachers rarely have time for. China sends retired principals and senior teachers to rural schools to coach young colleagues, and programmes in the United States and Spain have used retired teachers as mentors for novice and student teachers or as tutors for pupils who are falling behind.

The policies target the three profiles of former teachers unevenly. Of the 30 policies, 19 address retired teachers only, 7 address switchers and leavers, and 4 are open to all three profiles. The prominence of retirees has a simple

explanation. They are easy to identify, they are fully qualified, many retire before they wish to stop working altogether, and the main obstacle to their return is a rule that governments control directly, namely the reduction or suspension of the pension when a retiree takes paid work in the public sector. Changing that rule is the most common policy in the review, and it explains why financial incentives are the largest category in Table 2.

Most of these policies are short-term remedies. Several were enacted with a fixed end date and then renewed one period at a time: Ireland's waiver of pension abatement was introduced in 2021 and has been extended twice, most recently to the end of 2027; Michigan's rules expire in October 2028; Georgia's law expired in June 2026 and was replaced by a new one that sunsets in 2030; and Quebec's incentives are renegotiated every school year with the teacher unions. Others were reversed. Ontario's teachers' federation declined to extend the higher limit on working days in 2024, and Portugal repealed its scheme for hiring retired teachers in September 2026, two years after creating it (Government of Portugal, 2026). This pattern reflects the purpose of the policies, which is to fill vacancies quickly. Few treat former teachers as a permanent source of supply.

Where take-up is reported, it is small relative to the size of the teaching workforce. In Germany, a survey of the federal states counted more than 5 000 retired teachers who had stayed on or returned by 2023, under 1% of the teaching workforce (Deutsches Schulportal, 2023). In Georgia, retirees hired under the state's return-to-work law averaged about 350 a year, also under 1% of teachers (Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts, 2025), and Portugal validated 55 retired teachers against a quota of 200 places (Observador, 2024). Returners nonetheless form a large share of new entrants in some systems. In England, returners accounted for 17 740 full-time equivalent qualified teachers entering state schools in 2025/26, 43% of all qualified entrants and more than the 16 300 newly qualified teachers (Department for Education, 2026a). Most of these returners came back without any dedicated programme, which suggests that the size of the margin depends more on the conditions of the profession than on any single instrument.

Evidence on effectiveness is scarce. Only a handful of the policies have been evaluated, and only three of those evaluations, all concerning flexible positions, are randomised trials. Two official evaluations of re-entry programmes, in England and the Netherlands, found low conversion or substantial deadweight, and a third, in Sweden, found that a refresher course barely reached its target group. The retention of returners once back in school is almost never measured; Georgia, where 43% of the retirees hired in 2023 were still teaching two years later, is an exception. The sections that follow describe each instrument in turn, illustrated with selected country cases.

Table 2. Policies reviewed, by main instrument and target group

Instrument	Policies reviewed (target group)
Financial incentives	Canada, Ontario (R); Canada, Quebec (R); France (R); Germany, Lower Saxony, earnings ceiling (R); Ireland (R); Netherlands (S/L); Portugal (R); United States: Georgia (R), Louisiana (R), Michigan (R), New Mexico (R), North Carolina (R)
Information and nudges	Australia, New South Wales (All); Austria (R); Germany, Lower Saxony, letter (R); Japan, Miyazaki (S/L); United Kingdom, England, advisers (S/L)
Support and training	Australia, Victoria (All); Sweden (S/L); Switzerland, Zurich (S/L); United Kingdom, England, pilot programme (S/L)
Flexible positions	Bahamas (All); China (R); Singapore (All); Spain, Zaragoza (R); United States: AARP Foundation Experience Corps (R), Colorado (R), four urban districts (R)
Flexible re-certification	New Zealand (S/L); United States, Virginia (R)

Note: R: retired teachers; S/L: switchers and leavers; All: all three profiles. Each policy is listed under its main instrument; many use secondary instruments as well, which are discussed in the text. AARP Foundation Experience Corps recruits older adults in general, not only former teachers.

Source: Authors' compilation from official sources, verified in October 2026.

3.2 Financial incentives

Financial incentives take two forms. The first, and by far the most common, is a change in the rules that govern how pension and salary can be combined, which allows retired teachers to return without losing all or part of their pension. The second consists of direct payments, either to the returning teacher or to the school that hires them.

Combining pension and salary

In most public-service pension schemes, a retired teacher who takes paid work in the public sector sees the pension reduced or suspended once pension and new salary together exceed a threshold, as discussed in Section 2. The policies in this group relax that rule, and they differ mainly in how far they relax it and on what conditions. Some allow a limited number of working days a year without any reduction: Ireland waives abatement for the first 50 days a retired teacher works in a calendar year, provided that the need cannot practicably be met in another way (Department of Education, 2026), and Ontario allows retirees to work 50 days in a school year, a limit that was raised to 95 days in each of the three school years from 2020-21 to 2022-23 (Ontario Teachers' Federation, 2020). Others raise or remove the earnings ceiling. Lower Saxony temporarily raised it to 150% of the pensionable salary in 2022 and abolished it in 2024 for retirees who have reached the statutory age (Box 4), and Michigan lets retirees return to any post without an earnings limit once they have been retired for six months (Michigan Office of Retirement Services, 2023). France allows full cumulation of pension and salary to retirees who receive a full-rate pension and caps earnings for the rest (Assemblée nationale, 2026).

Several systems attach conditions that target the policy on shortages. In the United States, Georgia required 30 years of service and a full-time post in a

subject of high need (Box 3), Louisiana and Virginia restrict the full return to posts declared critical shortages, and Virginia's rule, in force since 2001, applies only after a break in service that was shortened from 12 to 6 months in 2023 (Virginia Retirement System, 2023). Portugal allowed schools to hire retired teachers for hard-to-fill posts within a national quota (Government of Portugal, 2024). Many schemes also decide whether returners keep paying into the pension fund. In Georgia and New Mexico, contributions continue to be paid on the returner's salary but earn no further pension rights, which limits the cost of the policy to the pension system.

The evidence on these rules points in three directions. First, the conditions matter as much as the incentive. When Virginia shortened the break in service from 12 to 6 months, retirees returning between July and October rose from 18 in 2022 to 150 in 2023 (Virginia Retirement System, 2023), whereas Portugal validated 55 retired teachers for a quota of 200 places before repealing the scheme. Second, rules of this kind tend to channel returners towards the schools that most need them. In North Carolina, where retired teachers could return full-time and keep their pension between 1999 and 2009, about 3 500 teachers did so, and 30% of them worked in schools in the poorest quartile, against 21% in the least poor (Jarrold-Grapes and Mahler, 2024). Third, they raise concerns that are worth anticipating. Ontario's teachers' federation refused to extend the higher limit in 2024, arguing that more than 30 000 certified teachers were not employed by school boards and that a generous rule could encourage early retirement (Ontario Teachers' Federation, 2024), and returners themselves may find the experience less rewarding than expected. In Austria, none of the 14 returning retirees interviewed in a 2025 study said they would repeat the experience (Resch, 2025).

Box 2. Quebec (Canada): paying retired teachers on the salary scale

Quebec's incentives for retired teachers were introduced in autumn 2020, during the COVID-19 health emergency, by a decree that modified the national and local collective agreements. Until then, a retiree who covered an absence was paid the flat daily rate for occasional supply teaching and reached the salary scale only after 20 consecutive days in the same replacement. Under the decree, a teacher who had retired in the previous five years was paid from the first day at the step of the single salary scale that matched their experience and qualifications, and kept the full pension. For a retiree at the top of the scale this roughly doubled the daily rate, from a usual maximum of about CAD 212 to about CAD 412 (Gouvernement du Québec, 2022).

From 1 October 2021 a temporary premium of 7.89% was added for retirees in the public-service pension plan. The emergency measures ended with the 2021-22 school year, and since 2022-23 the incentives have been renewed each year through letters of agreement signed outside the collective agreement with each teacher union federation. The premiums have changed from one agreement to the next: 7.89% until 2023-24, then 7.5% on supply work and 12.5% on contracts of three months or more in 2024-25, and only the 12.5% premium, now on contracts of one month or more, from 2025-26. Employers must first offer the work to qualified staff they already employ. Since 2024-25 the measures have been open to any retired teacher who is legally qualified to teach.

The ministry funds the measure after the fact, on the basis of the data that school service centres report each year on their use of retired staff. The envelope for

2026-27 is being adjusted downwards, as fewer retirees are used and the 7.5% premium has been withdrawn (Ministère de l'Éducation du Québec, 2026). About 700 retirees returned in 2020-21, and the ministry has reported more than 5 000 in 2024-25 (Le Devoir, 2025). The measure has not been evaluated.

Lessons. Paying returners on their own salary step removes the main financial penalty of supply work for experienced teachers, at a moderate cost, because the payment is made only for days actually worked. Its annual renegotiation keeps the measure responsive to shortages, but it also leaves retirees and school service centres uncertain about the terms from one year to the next.

Box 3. Georgia (United States): what an audit shows about returning retirees

Between July 2022 and June 2026, Georgia's House Bill 385 allowed teachers who had retired with at least 30 years of service, and had been retired for at least a year, to return to a full-time classroom post in one of the subjects of highest need in their region and draw a full salary on top of the full pension. The employer paid both the employer and the employee pension contributions, and the returner earned no further service credit (Teachers Retirement System of Georgia, 2026).

A state audit published in 2025 is one of the few assessments of such a rule. Between 2023 and 2025, 635 retirees returned under the law, rising from 241 to 428 a year, an average of about 350, or under 1% of the state's teachers. Just over half of school systems used it, and 64% of returners went back to the system they had retired from. Of the 2023 cohort, 43% were still teaching two years later. Among the systems that did not use the law, 45 of 72 said they would have liked to but could find no eligible retiree (Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts, 2025).

The law expired in June 2026 and was replaced by Senate Bill 150, which requires at least half of the returner's timetable to be in a qualifying subject and lets each school system define its own areas of highest need from a five-year average of vacancies, and expires in 2030.

Lessons. Strict eligibility keeps the cost of the rule low but also its reach, since the retirees who qualify are few and are concentrated where they used to work. Defining need locally, as the new law does, can bring the rule closer to the vacancies it is meant to fill.

Direct payments

Direct payments are less common. Quebec's measure, described in Box 2, is the clearest example of a payment to the returner. Victoria (Australia) pays former teachers a daily honorarium for a supported placement of up to 40 days (Box 7), and China pays the teachers it posts to rural schools an allowance of CNY 20 000 a year (Box 9). New Zealand has paid the registration fees of returning teachers since October 2024, a measure extended to all teachers from July 2025 (Box 10).

The Netherlands paid the school instead. Between 2017 and 2020, school boards received a flat EUR 2 500 for each qualified teacher they re-hired in primary education after at least a year away, to cover coaching and refresher training (Ministerie van OCW, 2017). The grant was used for 274 returners in

three years, well below the number the budget allowed, and school boards told the ministry that most of these teachers would have been hired and supported without it. The ministry concluded that the grant had contributed only to a limited extent and did not extend it (Tweede Kamer, 2020). The Dutch case illustrates a general risk of payments to employers, which is that they reward hiring decisions that would have been taken anyway.

3.3 Information and nudges

A second group of policies seeks to inform former teachers of the options available to them, or to prompt them to consider returning, through letters, telephone calls, advisers or information sessions. These instruments are cheap, and they address a barrier that the evidence in Section 2 suggests is real, namely that many former teachers are open to returning but are not asked, do not know how, or expect the process to be burdensome.

The timing and the messenger appear to matter. Austria offers a cautionary case. In December 2022 the education directorate of Vienna wrote to nearly 300 retired teachers and three returned; from February 2023 it asked school principals instead to talk in person with teachers approaching retirement age about staying on (ORF Wien, 2023). Other Austrian provinces followed different routes: Salzburg wrote to all retired teachers up to the age of 67, and Vorarlberg includes information on staying on with the forms teachers fill in to apply for their pension (ORF, 2023). Lower Saxony reached the same conclusion as Vienna, contacting teachers before they retire rather than after (Box 4). New South Wales (Australia) shows that outreach can also work with teachers who left recently, when it is accompanied by help with the procedures and by better conditions in the profession (Box 5).

England offers an advisory service, through which former teachers can ask for an adviser who supports them one to one with applications, interviews, refresher courses and vacancies; in 2026 the Department for Education committed to keeping it and added a step-by-step guide (Department for Education, 2026b). Japan illustrates a different use of information. Because any accredited university can award a teaching licence after a short practicum, Japan has a large pool of licence holders who have never taught or have long been away from schools. In 2023, 50 of the 68 prefectural and city boards of education ran sessions or training for these licence holders, and the national ministry funds such initiatives (MEXT, 2024). In Saitama, seven seminars in 2023 drew 226 participants, of whom 122 registered for temporary or part-time posts and 53 had been appointed by April 2024. The session held by the Miyazaki Prefectural Board of Education in November 2025 shows what teachers in this group are told: how a teacher's day has changed, what professional development is available, and which posts they can take without sitting the competitive examination, from temporary full-time teacher to part-time teacher or school support staff, before individual consultations and registration as a temporary teacher (Miyazaki Prefectural Board of Education, 2025).

None of these outreach initiatives has been formally evaluated, and in most cases the data do not allow returners to be linked to the contact that prompted them to return.

Box 4. Lower Saxony (Germany): a package for teachers about to retire

Lower Saxony's approach combines three instruments aimed at teachers approaching retirement. The first is financial. Under the civil-service pension law, a retired teacher working for the state had the pension reduced once pension and salary together exceeded a share of the former salary. In 2022 the state parliament raised that ceiling from 125% to 150% of the pensionable salary, which allowed a pensioner to teach about nine to ten lessons a week without any reduction, and in 2024 it abolished the ceiling for teachers who have reached the statutory retirement age (Niedersächsischer Landtag, 2024). Teachers who retire early remain subject to a ceiling.

The second is information. In November 2023 the Minister of Education wrote personally to every teacher about to retire, civil servants and salaried staff alike, thanking them for their service and setting out how they could stay on: a civil servant can ask to postpone retirement, and any teacher can be re-employed on a fixed-term contract immediately after retiring while drawing the pension. The letter went to teachers approaching retirement partly because the ministry no longer held the personnel files of those who had already retired. School principals were also asked to approach these teachers in person (Niedersächsisches Kultusministerium, 2023).

The third is administrative. A teacher who continues at their former school immediately after retiring does not need to apply through the online recruitment system or provide a new police certificate, and contact persons in each of the four regional school authorities advise retirees and handle the procedure. The number of teachers past retirement age working on fixed-term contracts rose from 229 in 2020 to 437 in 2024 (Niedersächsischer Landtag, 2025).

According to the ministry, most returners stay at or return to the school where they last taught, usually part-time and in a specific subject such as mathematics, and rarely as class teachers or formal mentors. The ministry stresses that the funding for these posts must be additional, so that retirees do not take positions from young teachers. No formal evaluation has been carried out, and the absence of a unique teacher identifier prevents the state from following individual careers.

Lessons. The financial change was one part of a package. Reaching teachers before they retire, through a personal letter and their own principal, and simplifying the procedure for those who simply continue at their school, make the decision to stay a small step instead of a new application.

Box 5. New South Wales (Australia): calling back recent leavers

In November 2023 the New South Wales Department of Education contacted more than 1 500 teachers who had left its schools in the previous five years and asked them to consider returning. Those interested were offered a simpler re-employment process, help with accreditation, approval to teach and the working-with-children check, and placement in casual or temporary work, with permanent posts and small-group tutoring roles also available.

By May 2024 more than 260 had expressed interest and 145 had been matched with schools, about 60% of them coming back from retirement (NSW Government, 2024). The campaign followed the largest pay rise for the state's teachers in decades, effective from October 2023, which raised the starting salary from AUD 75 791 to AUD 85 000, together with a reduction in administrative workload.

Teacher vacancies in the state fell from a peak of 3 311 in 2022 to 1 294 in February 2025, although the contribution of returners to that fall is not known.

Lessons. Recent leavers can be identified from the employer's own records, and a direct call with practical help converted about one in ten of those contacted. That the call coincided with better pay and a lighter administrative load is consistent with the evidence in Section 2 that conditions, more than information alone, determine whether former teachers are willing to return.

3.4 Support and training

A third group of policies reduces the practical cost of returning, through refresher courses, supervised time in classrooms, coaching and induction. These measures respond to the uncertainty that former teachers often report about changes in curricula, assessment and classroom practice, and to their lack of recent experience, which schools may also see as a risk.

The evidence on these programmes is sobering, and it is unusually rich for a field with so few evaluations. England's Return to Teaching pilot drew far more interest than it could convert into posts (Box 6). Sweden's National Agency for Education launched a free online course for returning teachers in 2018, covering the changes in curricula, laws and guidelines since the reforms of 2010 and 2011. By April 2020, 1 018 people had registered, 175 had completed at least one module and 38 had completed the whole course; only about a third of respondents to the follow-up survey were actually returning teachers, and none of those who were employed had been given working time or a mentor to take it. The agency concluded that the course had not reached its target group (Skolverket, 2020).

Programmes that build re-entry into the school itself appear more promising, although they have not been evaluated either. In the canton of Zurich (Switzerland), teachers returning after eight years or more are entitled to the same induction as new teachers during their first year back, free of charge, including mentoring by a trained colleague in their own school, supervision and subject coaching, and they can obtain an individual assessment of what preparation their return requires (PH Zürich, 2026). In October 2026, however, the college was not offering counselling for returners. Victoria (Australia) pays former teachers for up to 40 days in a school, observing and teaching alongside serving teachers before they apply for a post (Box 7).

Box 6. England (United Kingdom): lessons from the evaluation of a return-to-teaching pilot

Between January and October 2016, the Department for Education funded 60 partnerships of schools to support qualified teachers returning to secondary subjects in shortage, with subject training, updates on assessment and behaviour management, classroom experience and mentoring, free of charge for the returner. The pilot attracted 5 729 registrations, well above its target of 3 000. Of these, 354 received support, 62 were teaching in a state school by November 2016 and 27 held a permanent post in the targeted subjects. The cost per additional returner was about GBP 37 400, close to the cost of training a new teacher, and the independent evaluation judged the pilot unlikely to represent good value for

money (Buchanan et al., 2018).

The evaluation identified several reasons for the low conversion. Support was offered from January, when few posts for the following September remained open. Many schools hesitated to give returners teaching practice, citing the need to establish their quality and the risk of disrupting lessons, and only 44% of returners felt their needs had been met. Half of the returners interviewed wanted part-time work, which few schools offered. Returners named their lack of recent experience, workload, the lack of flexible posts and their own confidence as the main barriers. A follow-up programme in 2016-17 tied support to identified vacancies, made teaching practice compulsory and paid returners a bursary of up to GBP 600 for childcare or travel, but was not evaluated.

Lessons. Registrations far exceeded the target, and the losses came later. Re-entry support converts best when it is timed to the recruitment calendar, linked to real vacancies, includes time in front of a class, and is matched by schools willing to offer the part-time posts that many returners want.

Box 7. Victoria (Australia): a paid placement before applying

Victoria's Teacher Re-Engagement Initiative, launched in late 2022, offers qualified teachers who have been away from teaching for at least 12 months a paid placement of up to 40 days in a government school. During the placement they observe classes and school routines with the mentoring of serving staff before they apply for a post. A central team matches participants with schools by subject, experience, location and availability, and records at the end of the placement whether the participant has re-engaged with teaching.

The initiative drew more than 1 100 expressions of interest and received AUD 12 million in the 2023-24 state budget (Victorian Government, 2026). It is now funded by the schools that host a returner, at AUD 330 per day to cover the participant's honorarium and administrative costs. No figures have been published on the number of participants who went on to teach.

Lessons. A supervised placement addresses at once the returner's lack of confidence and the school's uncertainty about the returner, the two obstacles that the English evaluation identified. Shifting the cost to schools may limit take-up to those that can afford it.

3.5 Flexible positions

A fourth group of policies offers former teachers roles other than a full-time teaching post, such as relief and adjunct teaching, tutoring and mentoring. These roles match the preferences that many former teachers express, particularly leavers with care responsibilities and retirees who want to work part of the week, and they allow systems to use experience where it is most valuable.

Pools of flexible teachers are the simplest version. Singapore has run an adjunct scheme for former teachers since 2004 (Box 8), and the Bahamas announced in July 2026 a reserve of former teachers, retirees and graduates, built on its supply-teacher platform, as part of a recruitment drive to fill about 300 vacancies across 162 public schools on 24 islands; more than 100 teachers had been recruited through the drive by September 2026 (Ministry of

Education of The Bahamas, 2026). China's Silver-Age Lecturing Plan places retired teachers in rural schools to teach and to coach the young teachers there (Box 9).

Mentoring and tutoring by retired teachers have been tested more rigorously than any other instrument in this review. In Aurora, Colorado, recently retired teachers and principals were paid to mentor teachers in their first three years in high-poverty elementary schools, for about an hour a week over two years. A randomised trial found a small positive effect on pupils' mathematics after the first year, of similar size but no longer significant after the second, and no significant effect on whether the mentored teachers stayed (DeCesare et al., 2017). Tutoring shows larger effects. In a randomised trial in 76 schools in four urban districts of the United States, first graders with weak number skills who received about 30 hours of small-group mathematics tutoring, mostly from retired and substitute teachers, outperformed their peers by an effect size of 0.34 (Gersten et al., 2015). AARP Foundation Experience Corps, which trains adults over 50, among them former teachers, to tutor young readers, improved reading comprehension in a randomised evaluation (Morrow-Howell et al., 2009). These results are consistent with the broader experimental evidence on tutoring cited in Section 1, and they suggest that tutoring is one of the most productive uses of former teachers who do not wish to return to a full post. Smaller initiatives point in the same direction. At the University of Zaragoza (Spain), ten retired teachers mentored 57 student teachers in their final years in 2018 (Lizalde Gil and Cortés Pascual, 2019).

Box 8. Singapore: an adjunct scheme for former teachers

Singapore's Ministry of Education launched an adjunct teachers programme in 2004 to attract former trained teachers back to the profession on more flexible terms. Under the current Flexi-Adjunct Teaching Scheme, former teachers register on a ministry portal for three years, and schools contact them directly for appointments of one day to ten weeks, for teaching alone or for teaching and other duties agreed with the school. They are paid by the hour, in tiers that depend on experience, and earn leave once they have accumulated 90 days of service. A companion scheme offers former teachers contracts of one to one and a half years, full-time or part-time (Ministry of Education Singapore, 2026).

Between 2022 and 2024, about 220 teachers a year were engaged as flexi-adjunct teachers within twelve months of leaving the service. In the same period the annual resignation rate of teachers was 2.4%, and 1.7% excluding those who joined the scheme (Ministry of Education Singapore, 2025).

Lessons. A standing pool lets a system keep in contact with teachers at the moment they leave, before their skills and their links with schools fade, and lets those who left for family or other reasons keep a foot in the profession on terms they choose. Pay well below that of regular teachers keeps the scheme cheap but limits its use to occasional cover.

Box 9. China: retired teachers for rural schools

China's Silver-Age Lecturing Plan, launched in 2018 by the Ministries of Education and Finance, recruits retired principals, teaching researchers and senior teachers, generally aged 65 or under, to serve for at least a school year in

rural primary and lower-secondary schools in poor, ethnic-minority and border counties. They teach classes, observe and give demonstration lessons, coach the school's young teachers and help with school management, and retired principals may serve as deputy heads. They keep their pension and receive CNY 20 000 a year for living costs, travel and insurance, paid by the central government in western provinces, shared between central and provincial governments in central provinces, and paid by the province in eastern ones. Returning to one's own former school does not count (Ministry of Education and Ministry of Finance of the People's Republic of China, 2018).

More than 20 000 retired teachers had been recruited by mid-2023, and recent annual rounds have planned 6 000 to 7 000 places. In 2023 ten government departments set a target of about 120 000 retired teachers across all levels of education. The 2026 round places the coaching of young teachers at the centre of the role and introduces an assessment by the host school at the end of each placement (Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China, 2026).

Lessons. The plan uses retired teachers above all to transfer experience to schools that struggle to attract and develop teachers, which is the use of former teachers that the evidence on mentoring and peer learning supports.

3.6 Flexible re-certification

A final group of policies lowers the regulatory barriers to returning. As discussed in Section 2, licensing rules rarely drive qualified teachers out of the profession but can stand in the way of their return, since a teacher who has been away for several years may need to renew a lapsed licence or complete a refresher programme before teaching again. New Zealand has replaced its refresher course with a plan agreed with the employing school (Box 10). In the United States, Virginia instructed its licensing authority in 2022 to issue licences to retired teachers whose licences had lapsed, and launched an online licensing system in 2023 (Commonwealth of Virginia, 2022). Other policies include lighter forms of the same instrument, such as the help with accreditation that New South Wales offered to returners (Box 5).

Box 10. New Zealand: from a refresher course to a plan agreed with the school

To renew a practising certificate, a New Zealand teacher must have at least two years of satisfactory teaching in the previous five. Teachers who did not meet that requirement used to complete an external refresher programme, the Teacher Education Refresh, which was costly and could take months. Since September 2024 the Teaching Council has allowed returners with a job offer to replace it with a return-to-practice plan, and in December 2025 it made this route permanent, under the name Kia Maia, from January 2026 (Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand, 2025). The returner assesses, together with the principal of the school that has offered the job, what has changed since they last taught and which resources they will use to update their knowledge against each of the professional standards over their first year back. Both sign the plan, Council staff review it without assessing the teacher's competence, and the certificate is renewed. Without a job offer, the refresher programme is still likely to be required.

The government also paid the registration fees of returning teachers from October 2024, supporting 352 returners by April 2025, and has covered the fees of all

teachers since July 2025 with NZD 53.3 million over three years. Between January and October 2026, 501 teachers renewed their certificate through Kia Maia. Most worked in primary (198) or secondary (133) schools or in early childhood education (110), 84% were women, and 62% were aged 31 to 50, while 16% were 61 or older (Teaching Council of Aotearoa New Zealand, personal communication, October 2026). The pathway thus mainly brings back mid-career teachers who had stepped away.

Lessons. Replacing an external course with a plan agreed with the employing school removes a cost and a delay at the moment the returner has a job in hand, and it involves the principal in the returner's first year, which the evidence on induction and leadership in Section 2 suggests matters for whether they stay.

3.7 Taken together

The policies reviewed share three features. They are mostly reactive, introduced to fill vacancies quickly and renewed or withdrawn as shortages change. They focus on retired teachers, whose return depends on rules that governments can change at little cost, while switchers and leavers, who make up most former teachers below retirement age, are addressed by fewer and smaller programmes. And they are rarely evaluated, so that most of what is known about their effects comes from take-up figures that cannot separate the returners they attracted from those who would have come back anyway.

Read against the reasons for leaving reviewed in Section 2, the cases suggest that instruments work best in combination with the conditions that former teachers return to. Lower Saxony paired the removal of a financial penalty with a personal letter and a simpler procedure, New South Wales called back recent leavers after a large pay rise and a cut in administrative work, and New Zealand tied re-certification to a job offer and to the school's principal. Conversely, the programmes that offered support or money alone, without posts that suited returners or schools willing to take them, converted little of the interest they raised. The returners themselves appear to be most valuable when their role matches their experience, as mentors, tutors or flexible staff, and the strongest experimental evidence in this review concerns those roles.

4. Conclusions

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